Aquifer Open Study Notes (Profiles)

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This resource has been adapted into multiple languages, including English, Tok Pisin, Arabic (عربي), French (Français), Hindi (हिंदी), Indonesian (Bahasa Indonesia), Portuguese (Português), Russian (Русский), Spanish (Español), Swahili (Kiswahili), and Simplified Chinese (简体中文).

G

Gideon

Gideon was an Israelite judge and the son of Joash from the tribe of Manasseh. He said his clan was the weakest in Manasseh, and he was the least important in his clan. His story shows how God can use a weak person for great purposes.

During this period, Midian oppressed Israel, and the people cried out to God for help (Judges 6:6). In response, God sent a prophet to reprimand them for ignoring Him and worshiping other gods. He also sent His angel to call Gideon to save Israel.

Gideon's first appearance is not promising. He was threshing wheat at the bottom of a winepress to hide from the Midianites. When the angel of the Lord appeared to Gideon there, Gideon asked why God had not saved his people like during the Exodus. God told Gideon that he was chosen to be Israel's deliverer and that God would be with him. Gideon was hesitant to believe and asked for a sign. He brought an offering, and when the angel touched it, fire came from the rock beneath.

This sign gave Gideon enough faith to take action in his community. God instructed him to tear down his father's altar to Baal, cut down the Asherah pole, and build an altar to the Lord instead. Gideon obeyed God's command and became a warrior for God against false gods.

The Spirit of God came upon Gideon, and he gathered an army to fight the Midianites and their allies. Gideon remained cautious and asked God for another sign to confirm his mission. He placed a fleece outside on two different nights, asking God to show his power by making the dew settle on the fleece and the ground in miraculous ways. God did this, and Gideon was ready to follow God's plan.

Gideon successfully recruited 32,000 men for the army. However, God instructed him to reduce the number to 300 men. Gideon led these 300 men against a much larger force and won.

Gideon wisely refused the people's request to become their ruler. However, he made an ephod from the earrings of the defeated soldiers, and it became an idol (Judges 8:22–27). Gideon, who was weak in faith and relied on visible signs, eventually turned away from worshiping the invisible God and worshiped idols. Israel experienced peace during his lifetime, but his lack of faith led to problems after his death (Judges 8:33–9:57).

Passages for Further Study

Judges 6:1–8:35; 1 Samuel 12:11; Isaiah 10:26; Hebrews 11:32

The Greeks

Greek civilization was important in the ancient world. Greek culture greatly influenced the world during the birth of Jesus and the writing of the New Testament.

Mycenaean Civilization (1450 to 1200 BC)
The Mycenaeans lived during a time known as the heroic age, between 1450 and 1200 BC. This was a time when many famous Greek stories about heroes and great battles took place. These stories were later written down by Homer in his long poems. Their civilization was based in Mycenae, about thirty miles south of Corinth. The Mycenaeans traded widely and were very good at warfare. The Greek gods and myths known from later writings began in Mycenaean Greece. Mycenaean documents were written in Linear B, a script using syllables.

The Mycenaean civilization ended violently around 1200 BC due to Dorian Greek invaders. The following centuries are known as the Greek Dark Ages. During this time, people stopped using Linear B script, and there are no written records.

Archaic Age, City-States (850–546 BC)
Eventually, Greek towns and villages organized into city-states that controlled large areas. During this time, Greeks began to cooperate more and shared a common identity. For example, they held the first Olympic Games in 776 BC.

As trade with nearby regions grew, the Greeks met the Phoenicians and adopted their writing system. Homer wrote the Iliad and Odyssey, which tell the stories and myths of the earlier Mycenaean civilization and their gods.

Many city-states depended on a powerful leaders called tyrants. These leaders helped keep order and peace in their cities. (The Greek word for these rulers is tyrannos.) Many areas wrote down their basic laws in a document called a constitution. This helped create clear rules for governing. In Athens, a small group of powerful people called the Areopagus Council ruled the city. This type of government was called an oligarchy. Later, a leader named Solon made important changes to how Athens was governed. These changes helped Athens become a democracy, where citizens could vote and help make decisions.

The Greeks

Persian Wars, Classical Period (546 to 336 BC)
In 546 BC, Cyrus the Great of Persia took control of the Greek colonies in Asia Minor. Around 500 BC, Ionia tried to revolt but failed. This led Darius I to invade the Greek mainland in 492 BC. During the following wars, the Greeks were often outnumbered but used better skill and strategy to outmaneuver the Persians. In the Battle of Marathon in 490 BC, the Greeks defeated the Persians decisively. Ten years later, the Persian army under Xerxes crossed the Hellespont, and their large fleet entered Greek waters. The Persians burned Athens, but eventually, the Greeks won, and Xerxes withdrew.

After the Persian Wars ended, Athens was rebuilt and entered a period of greatness. Pericles led Athens to create a full democracy. They built large structures on the Acropolis. Athens became wealthy, and its sea power increased. This was a golden age of great achievements in art, thought, literature, and architecture.

Macedonian Empire, Hellenistic Civilization (336–146 BC)
Philip II of Macedon wanted to build an empire. He defeated Athens and Thebes in 338 BC and united Greece under the Macedonian Empire. After Philip's assassination in 336 BC, his son Alexander became the ruler. In 335 BC, Alexander destroyed Thebes, which had rebelled. He then quickly conquered Babylon and Persia (see Daniel 8:5–8). When Alexander died suddenly in 323 BC, his vast territories were divided among four generals. After some conflict, three major regions formed:

1. Egypt
2. Asia Minor, Syria, and Babylon
3. Macedonia and Achaia

Alexander's conquests spread Greek culture and influence across the ancient world. This clash between Greek culture and Judaism led to the Maccabean revolt in Judea in the 160s BC.

Roman Rule (168 BC to AD 330)
Rome began expanding its power into Greece in 198 BC. In 168 BC, Rome defeated the Macedonians at the Battle of Pydna. By 148 BC, Rome had annexed Macedonia as a province. Then, in 146 BC, Rome destroyed Corinth. Greece was now firmly under Roman control and remained so until Emperor Constantine made Byzantium the capital of the Roman Empire in AD 330. Greek culture and Roman rule set the stage for the life of Jesus and the start of Christianity.

Passages for Further Study

Daniel 8:5–8